stringent austerity program (Henning 2017). This program included deeply unpopular measures such as tax hikes, pension cuts, and labor market reforms, fueling widespread discontent across the country. By January 2015, this discontent culminated in the electoral victory of Syriza, a left-wing populist party led by Alexis Tsipras, which had campaigned on a staunchly anti-austerity and anti-IMF platform. Syriza's rise to power escalated tensions with the troika, as its supporters lambasted the IMF and EU as elitist institutions enforcing policies that disproportionately harmed ordinary Greeks.

Syriza's rhetoric painted the IMF as the architect of Greece's suffering. The party accused the "elites" at the IMF and EU of imposing austerity measures that exacerbated economic hardship while benefiting banks rather than the Greek people. Syriza supporters often referred to the "euro elite" as exploiting Greece for their gain,[99] amplifying claims that troika-imposed austerity had brought widespread poverty and spiraling debt. Such anti-elite sentiment, combined with Syriza's threats to exit the eurozone, created a fraught relationship between Greece and the troika (Henning 2017).

Faced with the prospect of Syriza's galvanizing of public opinion against its programs, the IMF adopted a strategy to counteract the rising tide of populism. Central to this effort was re-framing its image and policies to resonate with Greek citizens.[100] Recognizing the potential for public opposition to derail necessary reforms, the IMF employed populist-style messaging to recast itself as a champion of ordinary Greeks. In particular, it sought to highlight how reforming Greece's tax administration—one of the core conditions of its program—could reduce inequality, with the burden of payment falling on wealthy elites rather than on everyday citizens. As one senior IMF official explained, the Fund attempted to position itself as "a friend of the ordinary Greeks," emphasizing the benefits of targeting tax evasion by wealthy individuals and politically connected families.[101]

The IMF also sought to shift public perceptions through an aggressive communication campaign on social media.[102] Key figures like Christine Lagarde used platforms like Twitter to advocate for fairer tax systems and governance reforms. Lagarde tweeted messages such as "We need a tax system where multinational companies and wealthy individuals contribute a fair share to the public purse" and "Solid fiscal frameworks together with good governance and transparency give citizens confidence that fiscal